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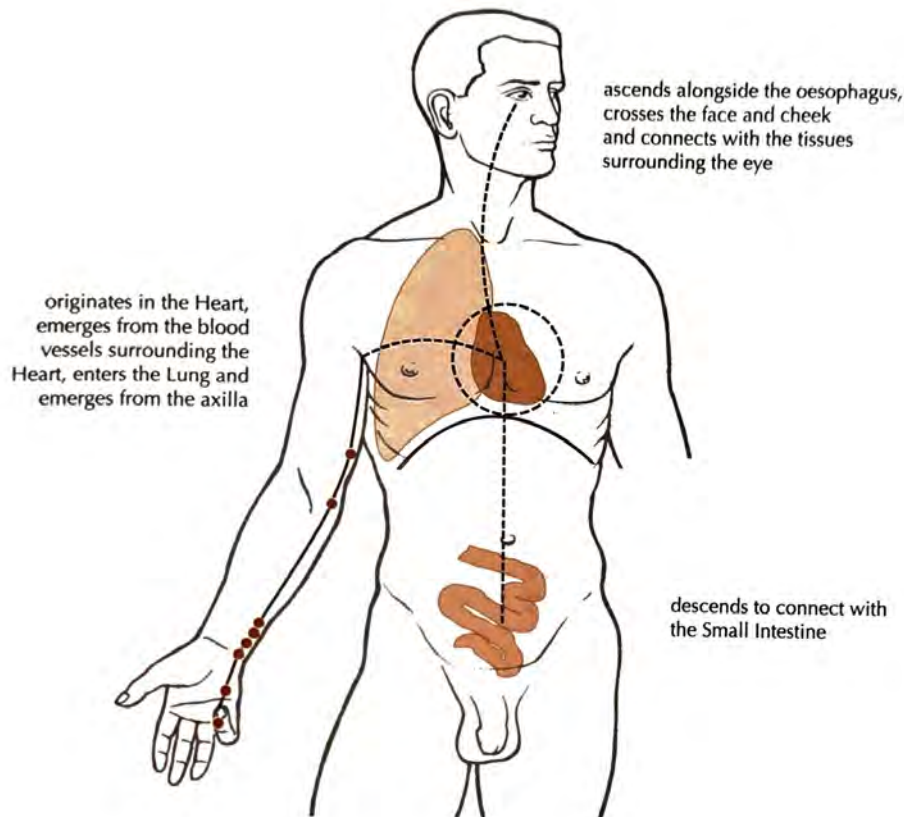
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THE HEART CHANNEL
OF HAND SHAOYIN

THE HEART CHANNEL OF HAND SHAOYIN



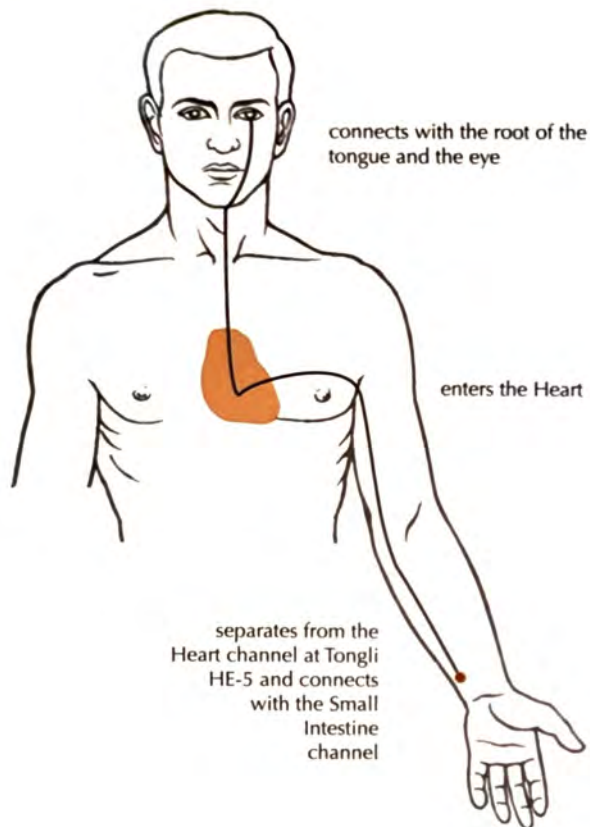
The Heart primary channel

THE HEART PRIMARY CHANNEL

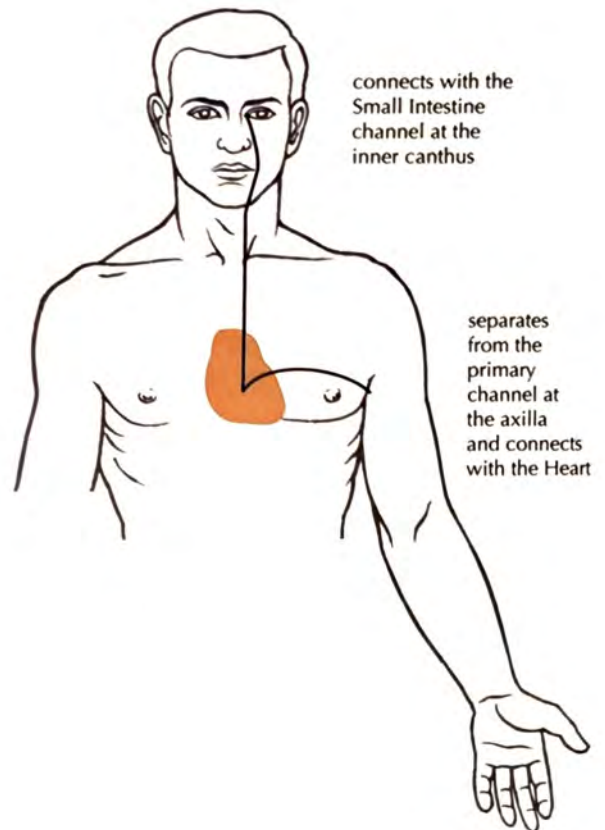
- originates in the Heart,
- emerges from the system of blood vessels surrounding the Heart and descends through the diaphragm to connect with the Small Intestine,
- a branch separates from the Heart, ascends alongside the oesophagus and then across the face and cheek to connect with the tissues surrounding the eye,
- another branch travels directly from the Heart to the Lung and descends to emerge from the axilla at Jiquan HE-1, then
- travels along the medial aspect of the upper arm (medial to the Lung and Pericardium channels) to the elbow at Shaohai HE-3,
- descends along the antero-medial aspect of the lower arm to the pisiform bone of the wrist at Shenmen HE-7,
- travels through the palm and along the radial side of the little finger to terminate at the radial corner of the nail at Shaochong HE-9.

The Heart primary channel connects with the following zangfu: Heart, Lung and Small Intestine.

The Heart primary channel meets with other channels at the following points: None.



The Heart luo-connecting channel



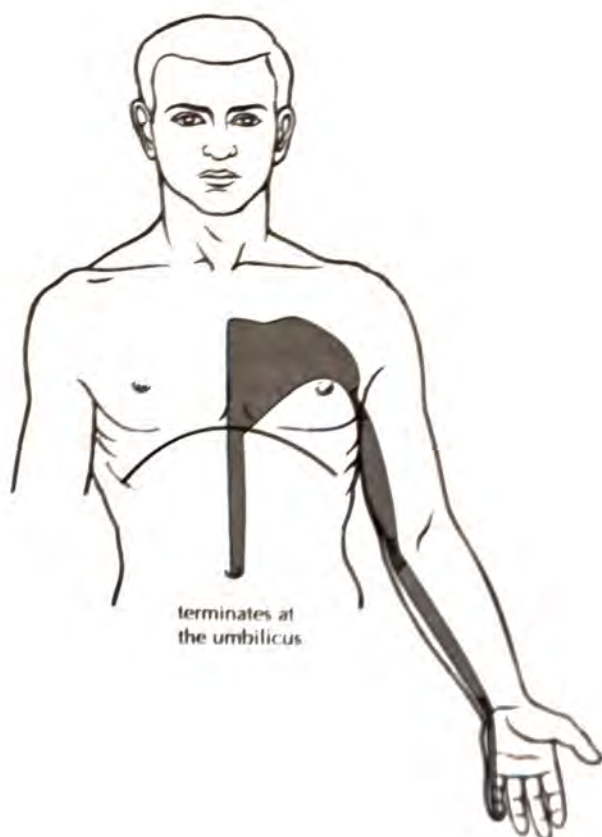
The Heart divergent channel

THE HEART LUO-CONNECTING CHANNEL

- separates from the Heart channel at Tongli HE-5 and connects with the Small Intestine channel,
- follows the Heart channel to the Heart zang then continues to the root of the tongue and the eye.

THE HEART DIVERGENT CHANNEL

- separates from the primary channel at the axillary fossa,
- enters the chest and connects with the Heart,
- ascends along the throat and emerges on the face, connecting with the Small Intestine channel at the inner canthus.



The Heart sinew channel

THE HEART SINEW CHANNEL

- originates at the radial aspect of the little finger and binds at the pisiform bone of the wrist,
- ascends to bind first at the medial aspect of the elbow and then at the axilla,
- enters the axilla, intersects the Lung sinew channel and travels medially across the breast region to the centre of the chest,
- descends across the diaphragm to terminate at the umbilicus.

Pathological symptoms of the Heart sinew channel
Internal tension, accumulation below the Heart, pain, cramping and strain along the course of the channel.

DISCUSSION

The Heart channel of hand shaoyin is interiorly-exteriorly coupled with the Small Intestine channel, and paired with the Kidney channel of foot shaoyin according to six channel theory. The Heart-Small Intestine relationship is further strengthened by the fact that:

- the Heart primary channel connects with the Small Intestine fu.
- the Heart divergent channel connects with the Small Intestine channel at the inner canthus.
- the Heart luo-connecting channel meets with the Small Intestine primary channel.

In addition, it is important to note that:

- a branch of the Heart primary channel ascends alongside the oesophagus.
- a branch of the Heart primary channel connects with the tissues surrounding the eye, the Heart divergent channel ascends to the inner canthus, and the Heart luo-connecting channel ascends to the eye.
- the Heart divergent channel emerges on the face.
- the Heart luo-connecting channel ascends to the root of the tongue.

The Heart has five principal functions:

- governing the blood and blood vessels
- housing the spirit
- opening into the tongue
- governing sweating
- manifesting in the complexion

It is by virtue of these functions, and the channel pathways listed above, that many of the actions and indications of the points of the Heart channel can be explained. These can be summarised as:

- Treating pain of the chest and Heart and disorders of Heart rhythm. According to the *Essential Questions* "All blood pertains to the Heart"¹ and "The Heart dominates the blood vessels of the body"². The qi of the Heart and Lung (with which the Heart channel connects) dominate the gathering qi and thus the circulation of the blood through the chest as well as the rhythmical beating of the heart. All the points of the Heart channel (with the exception of Qingling HE-2) therefore treat either pain of the Heart and chest, or palpitations and other disorders of heart rhythm. Acute pain of the Heart and chest may radiate along the Heart channel in the left arm, down to the abdomen (Heart primary and sinew channels) or up to the throat (Heart primary and divergent channels). In current clinical practice, points of the Pericardium channel are mostly favoured for pain of the chest and Heart, whilst disorders of Heart rhythm are treated by selecting points from both channels.

- Regulating and calming the spirit. According to the *Spiritual Pivot*³ "The Heart controls the vessels; the vessels are the residence of the spirit", whilst the *Essential Questions*⁴ says "The Heart stores the spirit". Points of the Heart channel, especially Tongli HE-5 and Shenmen HE-7, are among the most important of the acupuncture points to harmonise and calm the spirit, whether it loses its harmony due to deficiency and consequent lack of nourishment, to agitation by heat and fire, or to being obscured by phlegm.
- Treating disorders of the tongue and speech, including loss of voice, stiffness of the tongue, and painful and swollen tongue.
- Treating disorders of the throat such as pain, swelling and congestion.
- Treating disorders of the eyes. In addition to the Heart channel connections to the eyes, this may be explained by the fact that the Heart belongs to sovereign fire and the points of the Heart channel may be used to clear heat from any part of the body, in the case of the eyes manifesting as redness, swelling and pain.
- Treating various disorders of the face and complexion, thus for example Ma Dan-yang says of Shenmen HE-7 "when excess ... the head, cheeks and face are red, when deficient there is ... an expressionless face".

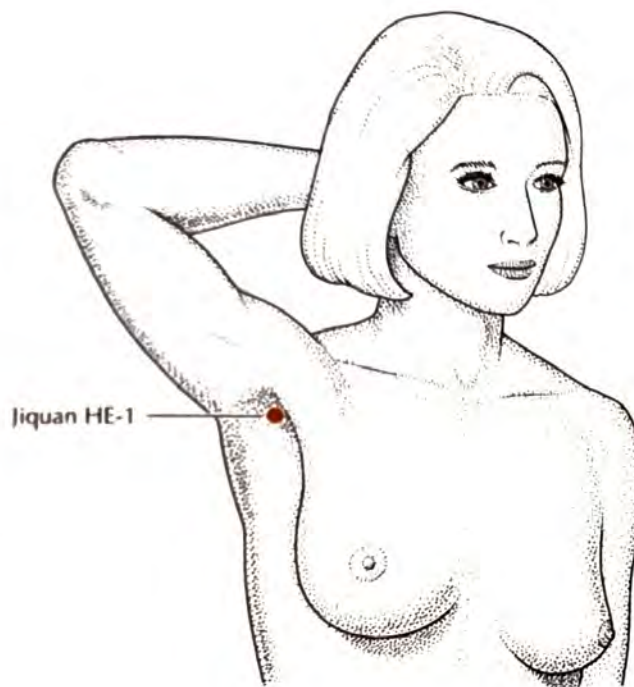
JÍQUÁN HE-1

Summit Spring

極泉

LOCATION

In the depression at the centre of the axilla.



LOCATION NOTE

This point is located with the arm abducted. Slide your finger up the lateral wall of the chest between the two muscle groups (latissimus dorsi posteriorly and pectoralis major anteriorly) into the depression at the highest point of the axillary hollow.

NEEDLING

Perpendicular insertion (in the direction of Jianjing GB-21) 0.5 to 1 cun, avoiding the axillary artery.

Caution: medial insertion towards the chest may puncture the lung.

ACTIONS

Unbinds the chest

Activates the channel and benefits the arm

INDICATIONS

- Heart painful obstruction, Heart pain with retching, chest pain, shortness of breath, distention and fullness of the lateral costal region, sadness and anxiety, palpitations, agitation with thirst and dry throat.

- Inability to raise the shoulder, pain of the axilla, scrofula, numbness and painful obstruction of the upper limb, inversion counterflow of the elbow and arm, cold and pain of the elbow and arm, loss of use of the four limbs, yellow eyes.

COMMENTARY

Jiquan HE-1 is the first point of the Heart channel, where the qi emerges from the Heart and its surrounding blood vessels. Located in the centre of the axilla, it is the point of communication between the Heart and chest on the one hand, and the arm on the other, and has an action on both these regions.

In the chest and lateral costal region it promotes the movement of qi and alleviates pain, being indicated for distention and fullness of the lateral costal region, chest pain and shortness of breath. In the Heart itself it treats pain manifesting as Heart painful obstruction and Heart pain with retching.

When the Heart yang declines, with concomitant blood stasis, qi and blood are unable to maintain their circulation through the channels and vessels of the arm, giving rise to numbness, whilst if the warming function of yang is impaired there will be coldness and pain. By promoting circulation of qi and blood throughout the arm, Jiquan HE-1 is able to treat these disorders.

The axillary region may be viewed as a gateway for the circulation of qi and blood through the arm, implied in the name 'Summit Spring'. In qigong practice and meditation, keeping the axilla slightly open is vital for maintaining the free flow of qi and blood through the upper limb. For this reason it is said that one should stand or sit with enough space in the axilla "to hold an egg". As a result, even in periods of long quiescence the arm and hands will stay warm.

COMBINATIONS

- Heart pain with retching, agitation and fullness: Jiquan HE-1 and Ximen P-4 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Dry throat: Jiquan HE-1, Taiyuan LU-9, Pianli LI-6, Taichong LIV-3 and Tiantu REN-22 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Loss of use of the four limbs: Jiquan HE-1, Riyue GB-24 and Pishu BL-20 (*Supplementing Life*).

QINGLING HE-2

Green Spirit

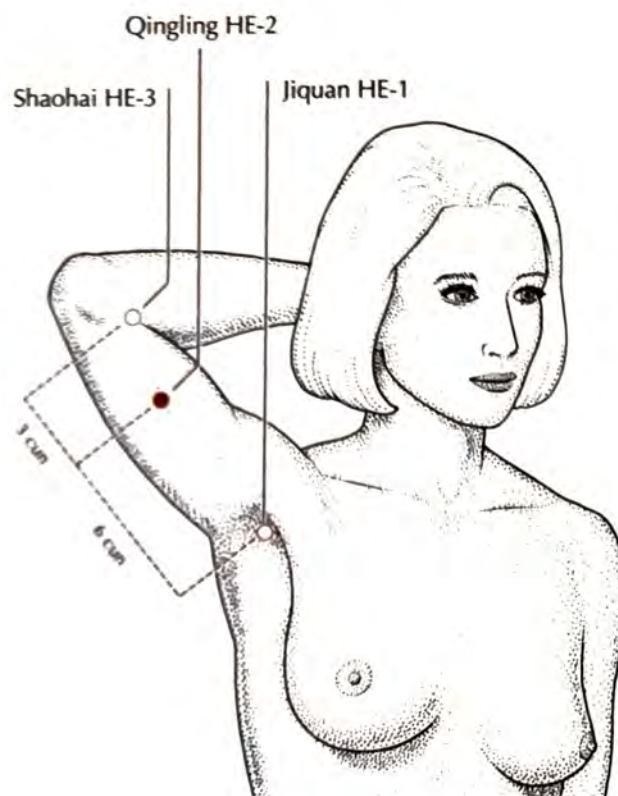
LOCATION

3 cun proximal to the medial end of the transverse cubital crease, on the line connecting Jiquan HE-1 and Shaohai HE-3.

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LOCATION NOTE

i. Locate with the elbow flexed; ii. This point is located in the groove medial to the biceps brachii muscle, one handbreadth proximal to Shaohai HE-3.



NEEDLING

Oblique distal or proximal insertion, 0.5 to 1 cun, avoiding the brachial artery. **Note:** many early classics only discuss moxibustion in relation to this point, implying that needling was contraindicated, perhaps because of the danger of damaging the brachial artery, whilst the *Introduction to Medicine* specifically contraindicates needling at this point.

ACTIONS

Activates the channel and alleviates pain

INDICATIONS

- Inability to raise the shoulder and arm, swelling, pain and redness of the shoulder, pain of the axilla, headache with cold shivering, yellow eyes, pain of the lateral costal region, scrofula.

COMBINATIONS

- Pain of the shoulder and upper arm: Qingling HE-2, Jianyu LI-15 and Quchi LI-11.

SHÀOHÀI HE-3

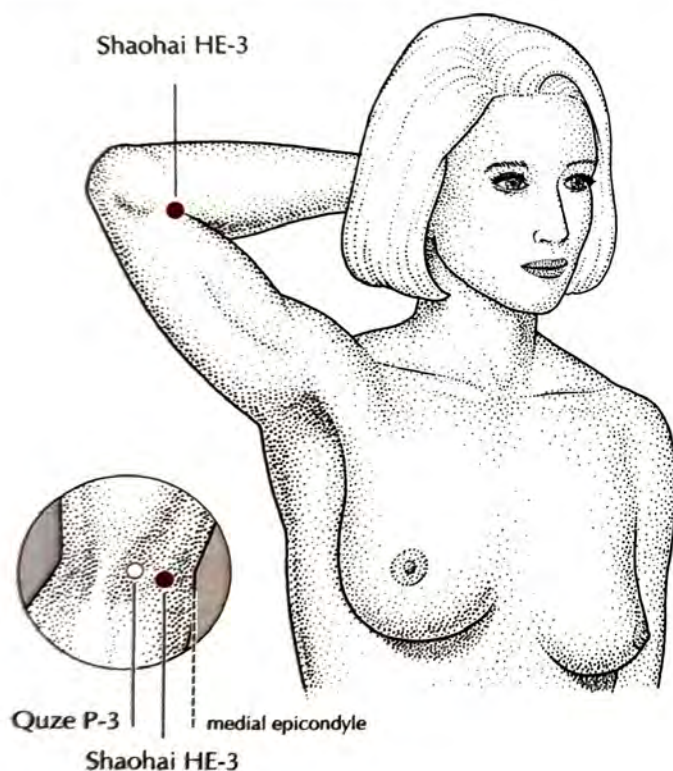
Lesser Sea

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He-Sea and Water point of the Heart channel

LOCATION

Midway between Quze P-3 and the medial epicondyle of the humerus, at the medial end of the transverse cubital crease when the elbow is fully flexed.



NEEDLING

Oblique insertion distally or proximally, or directed towards Quchi L.I.-11, 0.5 to 1.5 cun. **Note:** according to a number of classical sources this point is contraindicated to moxibustion.

ACTIONS

Calms the spirit, transforms phlegm and clears heat
Activates the channel and benefits the arm

INDICATIONS

- Heart pain, fullness of the chest, pain of the axilla and lateral costal region, mania and laughter, epilepsy, tongue thrusting, poor memory, vomiting of foamy (watery) saliva, scrofula.

- Red eyes, headache and wind dizziness, visual dizziness, toothache accompanied by chills and fever, erosion and swelling of the gums.
- Trembling of the hand and arm, numbness of the upper limb, inability to raise the four limbs, swelling and pain of the elbow joint, flaccidity of the elbow, inability to turn the neck, wind painful obstruction.

COMMENTARY

Shaohai HE-3 is the he-sea and water point of the Heart shaoyin (lesser yin) channel, hence the name Shaohai (Lesser Sea). It has three main spheres of action. Firstly it is able to calm the spirit, transform phlegm and clear heat, being indicated in such disorders as mania and laughter, epilepsy, tongue thrusting (where the tongue is repeatedly thrust out of the mouth like a snake's tongue) and poor memory, as well as other manifestations of phlegm such as vomiting of foamy saliva and scrofula. Clinically, however, it is less used for this purpose than points such as Jianshi P-5, Fenglong ST-40 and Tianjing SJ-10.

Secondly, as the water point of the Heart fire channel, Shaohai HE-3 is able to drain heat from the head manifesting as redness of the eyes, erosion and swelling of the gums, and toothache accompanied by chills and fever.

The third and main clinical application of Shaohai HE-3, however, is in the treatment of various disorders of the Heart channel in the upper limb. It is an important point for numbness and trembling of the arm and hand, and disorders of the elbow. According to the *Classic of the Jade Dragon* it is indicated for "fullness of the chest with agitation of the Heart accompanied by numbness and difficulty in raising the shoulder and arm". In the treatment of atrophy disorder and hemiplegia following windstroke, points of yangming channel, which is "abundant in qi and blood" have long been emphasised. Clinical practice has demonstrated, however, that better results are obtained when some points from yin channels are also selected. Due to the important action of Shaohai HE-3 on disorders of the whole arm, it is often stimulated by through needling from Quchi L.I.-11 in the treatment of these disorders.

COMBINATIONS

- Vomiting of foam: Shaohai HE-3, Duiduan DU-27 and Benshen GB-13 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Vomiting of foamy (watery) saliva: Shaohai HE-3 and Zhubin KID-9 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Scrofula: Shaohai HE-3, Tianchi P-1, Zhangmen LIV-13, Zulinqi GB-41, Zhigou SJ-6, Yangfu GB-38, Jianjing GB-21 and Shousanli L.I.-10 (*Great Compendium*).
- Scrofula: Shaohai HE-3 and Tianjing SJ-10 (*Song More Precious Than Jade*).

- Manic raving fear and fright: Shaohai HE-3, Zhizheng SI-7, Yuji LU-10, Hegu L.I.-4, Quchi L.I.-11 and Wangu SI-4 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Stiff tongue, tongue thrusting: Shaohai HE-3, Huaroumen ST-24 and Wenliu L.I.-7 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Stubborn numbness of both forearms: Shaohai HE-3 and Shousanli L.I.-10 (*One Hundred Symptoms*).

LÍNGDÀO HE-4

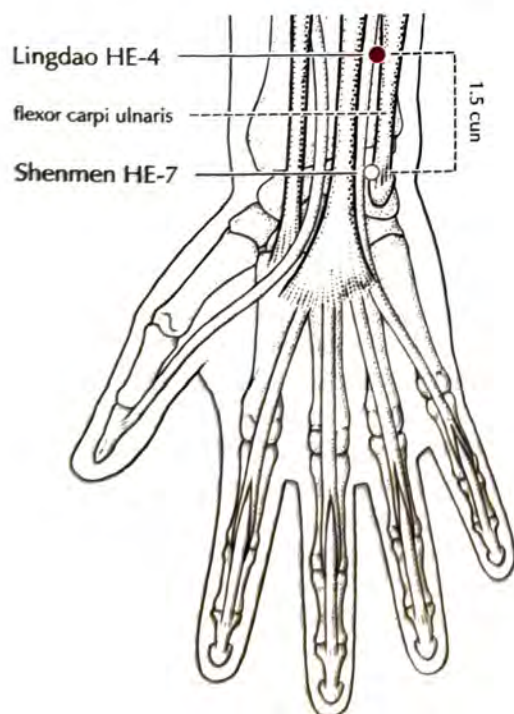
Spirit Path

Jing-River and Metal point of the Heart channel

LOCATION

On the radial side of the tendon of flexor carpi ulnaris, 1.5 cun proximal to Shenmen HE-7.

靈道



NEEDLING

Perpendicular insertion 0.3 to 0.5 cun, or oblique proximal or distal insertion 0.5 to 1 cun.

ACTIONS

Calms the spirit and benefits the voice
Relaxes the muscles and sinews

INDICATIONS

- Heart pain, sadness and fear, restless zang disorder, sudden loss of voice.
- Retching, throat abscess, redness and swelling of the eyes.
- Cold bones and marrow, clonic spasm, contraction of the elbow and arm, itching of the hand, swelling and pain of the fingers.

COMMENTARY

Lingdao HE-4, as its name 'Spirit Path' implies, has the ability to calm the spirit and is indicated for restless zang disorder and sadness and fear. Restless zang disorder is said to arise due to overthinking, excessive worry and anxiety which injure the Heart, Spleen and Liver. It is characterised by a wide variety of symptoms including unpredictable emotional responses, melancholy, disturbed behaviour, restlessness, insomnia, loss of voice and even mania. In terms of modern medicine it corresponds to hysterical neurosis. The ability of Lingdao HE-4 to treat sudden loss of voice (note combinations below) reflects its status as a jing-river point, since the *Spiritual Pivot*⁵ states that the jing-river points should be needled for changes manifesting in the patient's voice.

According to the *Spiritual Pivot*⁶ "when the disease is at the yin within yang (sinews and bones), needle the jing-river point of the yin". Lingdao HE-4, the jing-river point of the Heart channel, is indicated for contraction of the elbow and arm and a freezing cold sensation deep within the marrow and bones.

COMBINATIONS

- Sudden loss of voice with lockjaw: Lingdao HE-4, Tiantu REN-22 and Tianchuang SI-16 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Sudden loss of voice: Lingdao HE-4, Zhigou SJ-6, Tianchuang SI-16, Futu L.I.-18 and Qubin GB-7 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Loss of voice: Lingdao HE-4, Tiantu REN-22, Yingu KID-10, Fuliu KID-7, Fenglong ST-40 and Rangu KID-2 (*Illustrated Supplement*).

TONGLI HE-5

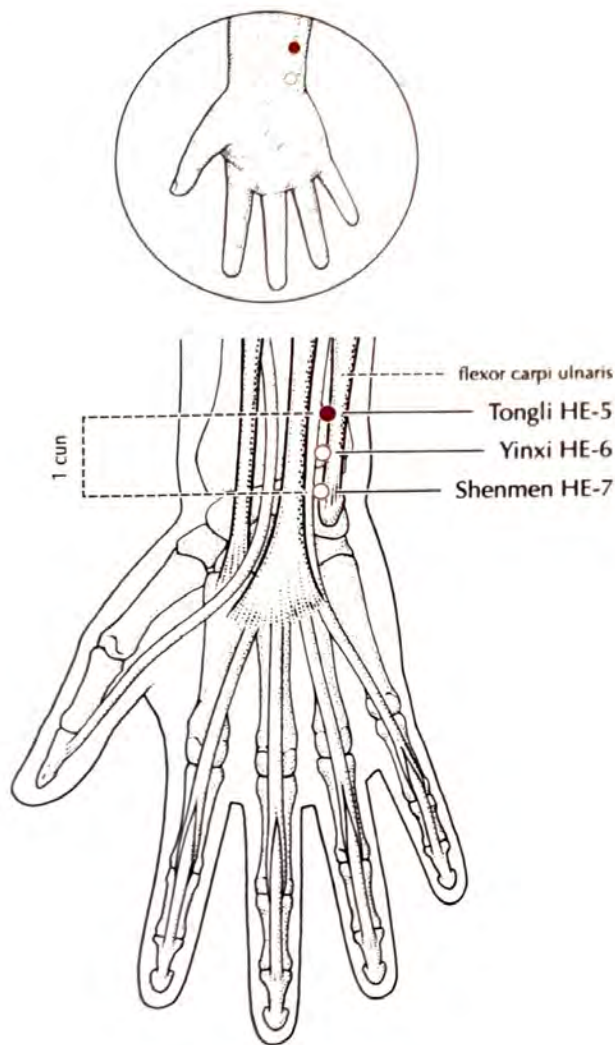
Penetrating the Interior

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Luo-Connecting point of the Heart channel
Ma Dan-yang Heavenly Star point

LOCATION

On the radial side of the tendon of flexor carpi ulnaris, 1 cun proximal to Shenmen HE-7.

**NEEDLING**

Perpendicular insertion 0.3 to 0.5 cun, or oblique proximal or distal insertion 0.5 to 1 cun.

ACTIONS

Calms the spirit
Regulates Heart rhythm
Benefits the tongue
Activates the channel and alleviates pain

INDICATIONS

- Frequent yawning and groaning with sadness, restless zang disorder, vexation and anger, sadness and fright, depressive disorder, pain and agitation of the Heart, frequent vexation with burning sensation of the heart, fullness and distention of the chest and diaphragm radiating to the lateral costal region.
- Palpitations, fright palpitations, pounding of the Heart, disorders of Heart rhythm, diminished qi.
- Sudden loss of voice, inability to speak, stuttering, stiffness of the tongue, eye pain, throat painful obstruction, red face with absence of sweating, head wind, headache and dizziness, visual dizziness, bitter vomiting.
- Menorrhagia, profuse uterine bleeding, enuresis.
- Pain and heaviness of the wrist and elbow, contraction of the fingers, pain of the elbow and upper arm, paralysis of the four limbs.

COMMENTARY

Tongli HE-5 was included by Ma Dan-yang, the great physician of the Jin dynasty, among the 'eleven heavenly star points', his grouping of the most vital acupuncture points, and was indicated by him for "inability to speak despite a desire to do so, vexation and anger, pounding of the Heart; when excess there is heaviness of the four limbs, and the head, cheeks and face are red; when deficient there is inability to eat, sudden loss of voice and an expressionless face".

Tongli HE-5 is the luo-connecting point of the Heart channel, from where the luo-connecting channel penetrates deeply into the Heart zang, strengthening the zang-channel relationship, hence the name 'Penetrating the Interior'. It has two principal actions on the Heart: i. to calm the spirit, and ii. to regulate Heart qi.

The *Spiritual Pivot*⁸ is the earliest text to record the fundamental principle that "the Heart is the residence of the spirit". The function of housing the spirit in Chinese medicine encompasses mental activity, consciousness, memory, thinking and sleep. At the same time it also refers to the totality of the emotional and spiritual life of a person. According to the *Ode of the Jade Dragon* "Tongli HE-5 treats a frightenable Heart". Tongli HE-5 shares with most of the other luo-connecting points of the yin channels (Lieque LU-7, Gongsun SP-4, Dazhong KID-4, Ligou LIV-5 and Neiguan P-6) the special ability to treat psycho-emotional disorders, but as the luo-connecting point of the Heart zang it is especially suitable for this purpose and is wide-ranging in its effect. Its action on calming the spirit, however, focuses on emotional disorders, rather than disturbances of sleep or memory, for which Shenmen HE-7 is more effective. According

to Fei Bo-xiong⁹ "The seven emotions injure the five yin organs selectively but they all affect the Heart". Tongli HE-5 is classically indicated for many different emotional manifestations, not only fright and agitation which are traditionally associated with disharmony of the Heart, but fear, vexation, anger, sadness and depression which are usually considered to injure, or result from injury to, other zangfu. The great doctor Hua Tuo said of the relationship between the Heart and fear "excessive thought gives rise to apprehension, and apprehension injures the Heart; an injured Heart gives rise to loss of spirit, and loss of spirit gives rise to fright and fear"¹⁰.

As for regulating the Heart qi, Tongli HE-5 plays an important role in the treatment of palpitations, fright palpitations, pounding of the Heart and disorders of heart rhythm. In Chinese medicine, palpitations are subdivided into i. simple palpitations which is a general term, ii. fright palpitations which denotes palpitations that are either triggered by or accompanied by feelings of fright, and iii. pounding of the Heart (the most serious kind) which denotes palpitations which may be felt as high up as the heart itself, or as low as the umbilicus (the termination point of the Heart sinew channel). Palpitations may accompany any pattern of the Heart zang, but as a disorder of the rhythmical beating of the heart they always involve the Heart qi.

The pathways of the Heart primary and secondary channels serve to clarify various other classical indications of this point. According to a saying of Chinese medicine, "the tongue is the sprouting forth of the Heart", and the Heart luo-connecting channel, after entering the Heart zang, ascends to the root of the tongue. For this reason, Tongli HE-5 is the primary point to treat loss of voice and stiffness of the tongue which affects the speech, usually resulting from mental disorders or the sequelae of windstroke. It is also indicated for the treatment of stuttering. The Heart channel connects with the tissues surrounding the eye, whilst the luo-connecting channel from Tongli HE-5 both spreads to the Heart's interiorly-exteriorly coupled Small Intestine channel and ascends to the eye. Tongli HE-5 is indicated for (and included in a number of classical combinations for) head wind, headache and dizziness, all of which may be accompanied by redness or pain of the eyes. These symptoms reflect disharmony of both coupled channels.

The Small Intestine channel is paired with the Bladder channel (taiyang) according to six channel theory. This Heart-Small Intestine-Bladder linkage has traditionally been used to explain the relationship between Heart disharmony and urinary disorders, since heat can transmit from the Heart to the Small Intestine and thence to the Bladder, and in the case of Tongli HE-5 its ability to treat enuresis due to accumulation of heat in the Bladder.

The Heart governs blood, whilst according to the *Essential Questions*¹¹ "The bao mai [uterine channel] pertains to the Heart and is connected with the uterus". If, due to emotional factors, heat accumulates in the Heart and enters the blood, there may be uterine bleeding or menorrhagia due to reckless movement of the blood. Tongli HE-5 is the only point on the Heart channel with such gynaecological indications.

Finally the *Great Compendium of Acupuncture and Moxibustion* gives specific indications for excess and deficiency of the luo-connecting points. In the case of Tongli HE-5 these are: fullness and distention of the chest and diaphragm radiating to the lateral costal region (excess); and inability to speak (deficiency).

COMBINATIONS

- Weary speech and somnolence: Tongli HE-5 and Dazhong KID-4 (*One Hundred Symptoms*).
- Sudden loss of speech: Tongli HE-5 and Yifeng SJ-17 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Head wind, redness of the face and eyes: Tongli HE-5 and Jiexi ST-41 (*Great Compendium*).
- Pain of the head and eyes: Tongli HE-5, Baihui DU-20 and Houding DU-19 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Headache and dizziness: Tongli HE-5, Feiyang BL-58, Kunlun BL-60, Ququan LIV-8, Qianggu SI-2 and Shaoze SI-1 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Enuresis: Tongli HE-5, Jimen SP-11, Dadun LIV-1, Pangguangshu BL-28, Taichong LIV-3, Weizhong BL-40 and Shenmen HE-7 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Irregular Heart rhythm: Tongli HE-5, Neiguan P-6, Jueyinshu BL-14 and Xinshu BL-15.

YĪNXĪ HE-6

Yin Cleft

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Xi-Cleft point of the Heart channel

LOCATION

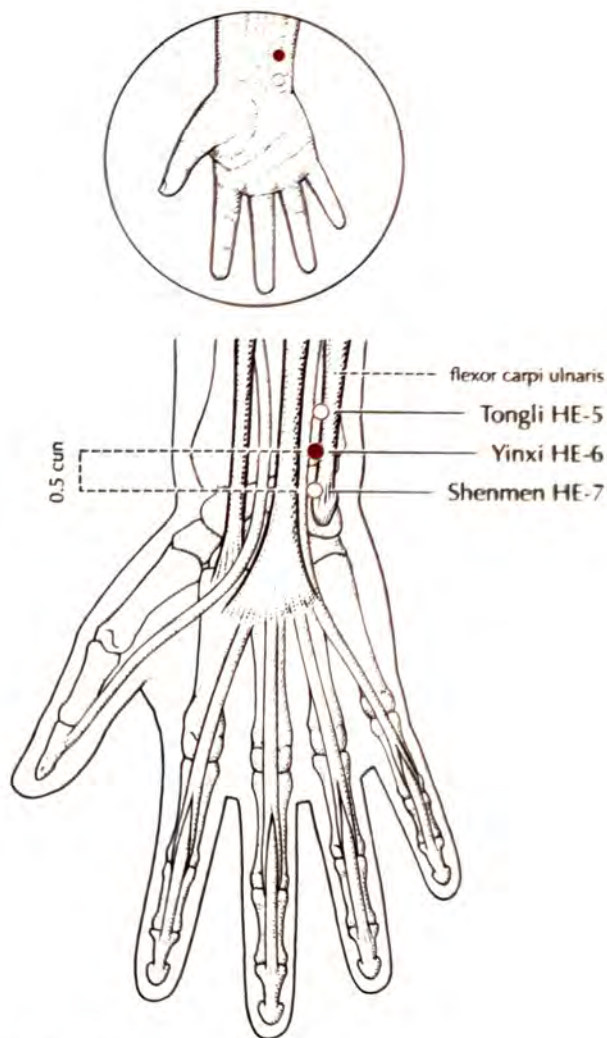
On the radial side of the tendon of flexor carpi ulnaris, 0.5 cun proximal to Shenmen HE-7.

NEEDLING

Perpendicular insertion 0.3 to 0.5 cun, or oblique proximal or distal insertion 0.5 to 1 cun.

ACTIONS

Regulates Heart blood
Calms the spirit
Moderates acute conditions
Clears deficiency fire and alleviates night sweating



INDICATIONS

- Heart pain, unbearable stabbing pain of the Heart, fullness of the chest, palpitations, fright palpitations, fright, counterflow inversion fright qi, epilepsy, loss of voice, sudden turmoil disorder with cardiac pain.
- Nosebleed, vomiting blood, counterflow qi.
- Night sweating, steaming bone disorder.

COMMENTARY

Yinxi HE-6 is the xi-cleft point of the Heart channel. The xi-cleft points are where the qi and blood, which flow relatively superficially along the channels from the jing-well points, gather and plunge more deeply. The xi-cleft points in general are indicated in the treatment of acute conditions and pain, whilst the xi-cleft points of the yin channels have an additional action of treating disorders of blood. Yinxi HE-6 is indicated for Heart pain due to blood stasis, and bleeding disorders due to excessive heat agitating the blood. However, in terms of both these actions, Ximen P-4 the xi-cleft point of the Pericardium channel, is clinically more important. Acute severe pain from blood stasis which threatens the survival of the Heart

zang is therefore primarily treated by using points of the Pericardium channel, the 'protector' of the Heart. This is reflected in the statement in the *Spiritual Pivot*¹² "The Heart is the great master of the five zang and six fu and the residence of the essence-spirit ... If the Heart is injured, the spirit will depart; if the spirit departs, the person will die ... therefore the pathogenic qi that attacks the Heart will be diverted to reside in the Pericardium".

The forte of Yinxi HE-6 lies in its ability to treat the yin fluids of the Heart. According to the *Ode to Elucidate Mysteries* "Reducing Yinxi HE-6 will stop night sweating and treat steaming bone disorder in children". This underlines the primary application of Yinxi HE-6 in clinical practice. According to *Essential Readings from the Medical Tradition* "That which is stored by the Heart internally is blood, externally it is emitted as sweat; sweat is the fluid of the Heart". Owing to this close relationship between the Heart blood and sweating, and the ability of the xi-cleft points to harmonise the blood, Yinxi HE-6 is an essential point in the treatment of night sweating due to deficiency of either yin or Heart blood. Night is the time of maximum yin, and during sleep (when the body is covered and the more yang defensive qi is no longer needed to protect the surface) the defensive qi enters deep within the yin to be nourished. If yin is deficient, it cannot draw and hold the defensive qi inside, and deficiency heat floats to the exterior and forces out the fluids as sweat. Alternatively, when Heart blood is deficient, the balance of qi and blood is disturbed and the qi floats to the surface causing night sweating, characterised by less intense heat sensations than the yin deficiency pattern. Controlling night sweating is always a priority of treatment, since the sweat emitted in this disorder (known in Chinese as 'robbing sweat') contains yin nutrient and its loss further aggravates the deficiency. It should be noted that night sweating, although most often due to the two patterns described above, may also occur as a result of other patterns of disharmony, specifically damp-heat, Spleen deficiency with retention of dampness, half-interior/half-exterior pathogen disorders and disharmony of nutritive qi and defensive qi. Due to its important action in stopping night sweating, Yinxi HE-6 may be used in any of these patterns in combination with appropriate points.

Steaming bone disorder is a form of fever from yin deficiency. It is characterised by a sensation of heat deep within the bones radiating outwards to the skin, and is accompanied by afternoon fever, restless sleep and night sweating. It is a profound form of yin deficiency with raging heat and is usually seen in the context of serious disease. Yinxi HE-6 is one of the principal points used to treat this pattern.

Finally, as the xi-cleft point of the Heart channel, Yinxi HE-6 is able to soothe and calm the Heart in acute situations and is indicated for acute fright - with or without palpitations. It is also specifically indicated for 'counterflow inversion fright qi'. This refers to loss of consciousness (inversion pattern) that arises when severe anger depresses the qi, or fright and fear rapidly and violently descend the qi.

COMBINATIONS

- Profuse night sweating: Yinxi HE-6 and Houxi SI-3 (*One Hundred Symptoms*).
- Excessive fright: Yinxi HE-6, Jianshi P-5, Erjian LI-2 and Lidui ST-45 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Heart pain with fullness and agitation and stiff tongue: Yinxi HE-6 and Zhongchong P-9 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Heart pain: Yinxi HE-6 and Xingjian LIV-2 (*Supplementing Life*).

SHÉN MÉN HE-7

Spirit Gate

Shu-Stream, Yuan-Source and Earth point of the Heart channel

LOCATION

At the wrist joint, on the radial side of flexor carpi ulnaris, in the depression at the proximal border of the pisiform bone.

LOCATION NOTE

i. The location of this point is normally given in relation to the crease of the wrist. Since wrist creases are a superficial and variable anatomical feature, it is better to locate this point in relation to the underlying pisiform bone; ii. When it is necessary to needle a patient in the prone position with the arms towards the head, this point may be located and needled on the ulnar side of flexor carpi ulnaris, very close to the tendon insertion; the needle is then directed beneath the tendon towards its radial side.

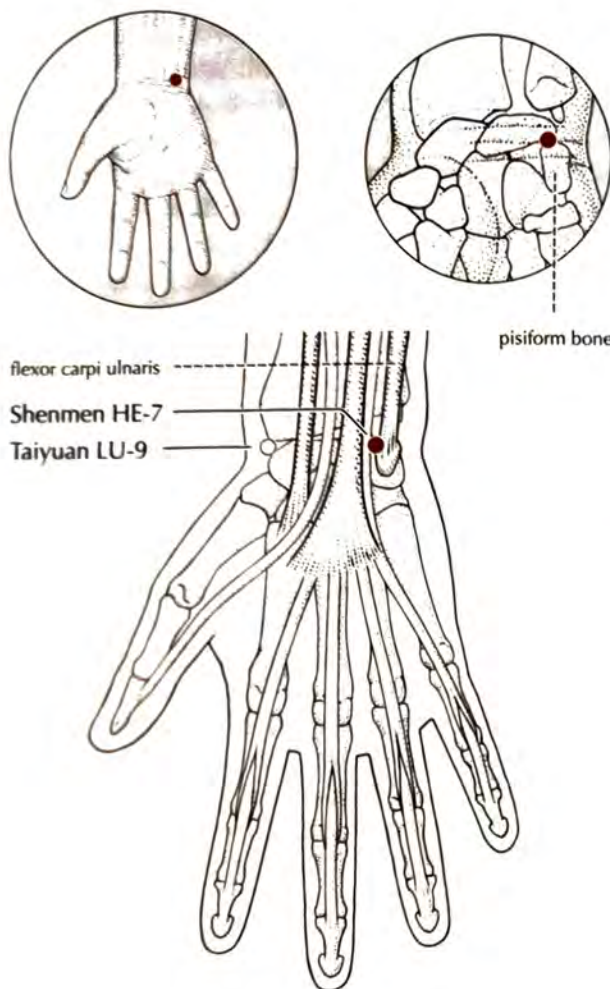
NEEDLING

Perpendicular insertion 0.3 to 0.5 cun, or oblique insertion proximally or distally 0.5 to 0.8 cun.

Caution: the ulnar artery and ulnar nerve lie adjacent to this point.

ACTIONS

Calms the spirit
Regulates and tonifies the Heart



INDICATIONS

- Insomnia, frequent talking during sleep, poor memory, mania-depression, epilepsy, dementia, desire to laugh, mad laughter, insulting people, sadness, fear and fright, disorientation, restless zang disorder, agitation of the Heart, malaria accompanied by agitation of the Heart, loss of voice.
- Heart pain, palpitations, fright palpitations, pounding of the Heart.
- Throat painful obstruction, dry throat with no desire to drink, vomiting blood, spitting blood, yellow eyes, pain of the lateral costal region, red face, heat of the palms, dyspnoea with heat in the body, shortness of breath, cold shivering, enuresis.

COMMENTARY

Shenmen HE-7 is the shu-stream and yuan-source point of the Heart channel. The *Spiritual Pivot* in Chapter 6 recommends the use of the shu-stream points in the treatment of disorders of the zang, whilst in Chapter 1 it says "When the five zang are diseased, select [from] the twelve

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yuan-source [points]". Shenmen HE-7 is an essential point to treat i. all disorders of the spirit, and ii. all deficiency disorders of the Heart zang.

Shenmen HE-7 (Spirit Gate) is the foremost acupuncture point to calm and regulate the spirit. According to the *Spiritual Pivot*¹³ "the Heart is the residence of the spirit". Disturbance of the spirit may broadly be divided into two main categories: deficiency patterns (mainly of Heart blood or yin) and excess patterns (Heart fire, phlegm or phlegm-fire). When Heart blood or yin are deficient they are no longer able to nourish the Heart and provide the material basis for the Heart to store and anchor the spirit. As a consequence the spirit loses its harmony and becomes restless and unquiet, resulting in such symptoms as anxiety and fearfulness, poor memory, restless zang disorder, insomnia and disturbed sleep. If Heart qi is deficient (especially when accompanied by qi deficiency of the Gall Bladder), a person will be easily frightened and apprehensive. According to the *Spiritual Pivot*¹⁴ "When Heart qi is deficient there is sadness; when excess there is ceaseless laughter". If the Heart loses contact with its associated emotion, joy, a person will be prone to ceaseless and inappropriate laughter. When Heart fire rages out of control it agitates and excites the spirit leading to such symptoms as severe insomnia and mental hyperactivity. When phlegm, or phlegm-fire, obstruct the portals of the Heart, the spirit will be disturbed to varying degrees, ranging from milder manifestations such as insomnia, talking during sleep, disorientation, agitation and restlessness, to the more severe symptoms of dementia, mania, mad laughter, insulting behaviour and epilepsy. Whatever the pattern, Shenmen HE-7 may be used to help restore peace and harmony to the spirit.

The Heart is unique in being susceptible to the four principal kinds of deficiency (qi, blood, yin and yang), Shenmen HE-7, the shu-stream and yuan-source point of the Heart channel, may be used in any of these situations, especially in cases of deficiency of blood and yin. In practice, the tonifying action of Shenmen HE-7 is enhanced and focused through its combination with other suitable points.

Palpitations are a common symptom of Heart disorder. Although fundamentally a disorder of Heart qi (the active, moving aspect of the Heart zang), palpitations may accompany virtually any Heart pattern, whether deficient or excess. Through its action of regulating and tonifying the qi of the Heart, Shenmen HE-7 is indicated for all kinds of palpitations, including fright palpitations and pounding of the Heart (see Tongli HE-5).

The Heart channel ascends to the throat and Shenmen HE-7 is able to clear heat from the channel giving rise to swelling, congestion, dryness and pain of the throat.

Finally, the Heart channel is interiorly-exteriorly coupled with the Small Intestine channel which is paired with the Bladder channel (taiyang) according to six channel theory. This linkage has traditionally been used to explain the relationship between Heart disharmony and urinary disorders, and in the case of Shenmen HE-7 its ability (emphasised in its inclusion in many classical combinations) to treat enuresis due to accumulation of heat in the Bladder.

COMBINATIONS

- Fear and fright with Heart pain: Shenmen HE-7, Shaochong HE-9, Yanglingquan GB-34 and Neiguan P-6 (*Compilation*).
- Fright palpitations with diminished qi: Shenmen HE-7, Ligou LIV-5 and Juque REN-14 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Heart painful obstruction, sadness and fear: Shenmen HE-7, Dadun LIV-1 and Yuji LU-10 (*Great Compendium*).
- Weeping with grief: Shenmen HE-7, Xinshu BL-15, Jiexi ST-41 and Daling P-7 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Dementia: Shenmen HE-7, Shaoshang LU-11, Yongquan KID-1 and Xinshu BL-15 (*Great Compendium*).
- Manic laughter: Shenmen HE-7 and Yanggu SI-5 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Mania, desires to ascend to high places and sing, discards clothing and runs around: Shenmen HE-7, Chongyang ST-42 and Houxi SI-3 (*Great Compendium*).
- Manic rushing around: Shenmen HE-7 and Shangwan REN-13 (*One Hundred Symptoms*).
- Epilepsy: Shenmen HE-7, Neiguan P-6, Houxi SI-3, Xinshu BL-15 and Yinbai SP-1 (*Complete Collection*).
- The five types of epilepsy: Shenmen HE-7, Jiuwei REN-15 and Houxi SI-3 (*Song More Precious Than Jade*).
- Heart pain: Shenmen HE-7, Jueyinshu BL-14 and Zulinqi GB-41 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Vomiting blood: Shenmen HE-7, Quze P-3 and Yuji LU-10 (*Great Compendium*).
- Enuresis: Shenmen HE-7, Guanmen ST-22 and Zhongfu LU-1 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Enuresis: Shenmen HE-7, Yuji LU-10, Taichong LIV-3, Dadun LIV-1 and Guanyuan REN-4 (*Great Compendium*).
- Enuresis: Shenmen HE-7, Guanmen ST-22 and Weizhong BL-40 (*Systematic Classic*).
- Enuresis: Shenmen HE-7, Pangguangshu BL-28, Tongli HE-5, Dadun LIV-1, Jimen SP-11, Taichong LIV-3 and Weizhong BL-40 (*Supplementing Life*).

SHÀOFŭ HE-8

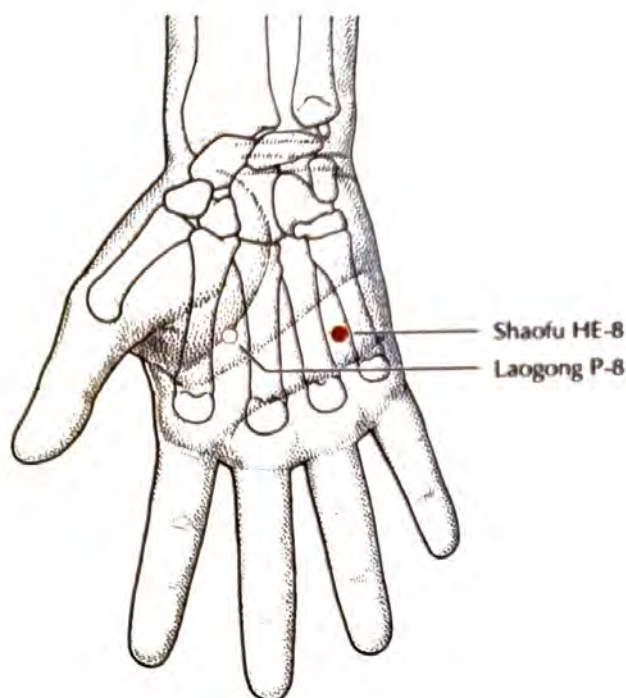
Lesser Palace

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Ying-Spring and Fire point of the Heart channel

LOCATION

On the palm, in the depression between the 4th and 5th metacarpal bones, where the tip of the little finger rests when a fist is made.

**LOCATION NOTE**

This point generally lies between the two transverse palmar creases.

NEEDLING

Perpendicular insertion 0.5 cun.

ACTIONS

Clears heat from the Heart and Small Intestine
Calms the spirit
Regulates Heart qi
Activates the channel and alleviates pain

INDICATIONS

- Palpitations, fright palpitations, sadness and worry with diminished qi, fear, fear of people, excessive sighing, plumstone qi (globus hystericus), chest pain, agitation and fullness, epilepsy.

- Itching of the genitals, pain of the genitals, difficult urination, enuresis, prolapse of the uterus.
- Chronic malaria, cold shivering, throat pain, stiffness of the tongue.
- Contraction of the little finger or hand, heat of the palms, pain of the arm, contraction of the elbow and axilla.

COMMENTARY

Shaofu HE-8 is the ying-spring and fire point of the Heart shaoyin (lesser yin) channel, hence the name 'Lesser Palace'. According to the *Classic of Difficulties*¹⁵ ying-spring points are indicated for "heat in the body", whilst a saying of Chinese medicine states "When the Heart is cleared [of heat] the urine will flow". Shaofu HE-8 is a major point for clearing Heart fire which transmits to the hand taiyang Small Intestine channel (its interiorly-exteriorly coupled channel), and thence to the foot taiyang Bladder channel (paired with the Small Intestine according to six channel theory), giving rise to a variety of urogenital symptoms including difficult urination, enuresis, and itching or pain of the genitals. The characteristic accompanying signs of this type of urogenital disorder are insomnia, emotional disturbance, thirst, and sores of the mouth and tongue. Although having some action of clearing Heart fire affecting the upper jiao in this way, Shaofu HE-8 is traditionally less indicated for this purpose than points such as Daling P-7 and Laogong P-8, and its primary application is to clear the lower jiao heat.

The second principal action of Shaofu HE-8 is to regulate the Heart qi in cases both of stagnation and deficiency. Stagnation of qi in the Heart and chest region, principally transmitted from the Liver and due to emotional factors, may present as pain and oppression of the chest accompanied by excessive sighing, fearfulness and even plumstone qi (globus hystericus), all indications classically recorded for this point. Equally, Shaofu HE-8 is indicated for a variety of emotional disorders due to deficiency of Heart qi. This kind of deficiency which often follows severe emotional shock or fright, may give rise to palpitations, sadness and worry (Heart and Lung qi deficiency) or excessive fearfulness (Heart and Gall Bladder qi deficiency), as well as excessive sighing which, although more commonly due to qi stagnation may also result from qi deficiency.

Shaofu HE-8 is indicated for a variety of Heart channel disorders including throat pain, stiff tongue, contracture of the elbow and axilla, and especially heat in the palms and contracture and pain of the little finger.

Finally, according to the *Essential Questions*¹¹ "The bao mai [uterine channel] pertains to the Heart and is connected with the uterus". Shaofu HE-8 is indicated for (and appears in classical combinations for) uterine prolapse.

COMBINATIONS

- Difficult urination or retention of urine: Shaofu HE-8 and Zusanli ST-36 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Uterine prolapse: Shaofu HE-8, Taichong LIV-3, Zhaohai KID-6 and Ququan LIV-8 (*Great Compendium*).
- Qi [stagnation] in the throat as if [obstructed by] a polyp: Shaofu HE-8 and Ligou LIV-5 (*Thousand Ducat Formulas*).
- Diminished qi: Shaofu HE-8, Pangguangshu BL-28, Shaochong HE-9, Bulang KID-22, Xingjian LIV-2, Shen-shu BL-23 and Shuiquan KID-5 (*Supplementing Life*).

SHÀOCHŌNG HE-9

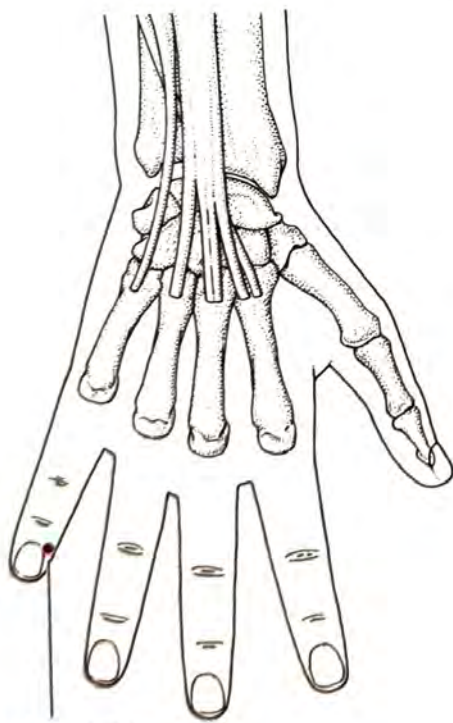
Lesser Rushing

Jing-Well and Wood point of the Heart channel

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LOCATION

On the dorsal aspect of the little finger, at the junction of lines drawn along the radial border of the nail and the base of the nail, approximately 0.1 cun from the corner of the nail.



Shaochong HE-9

NEEDLING

Perpendicular or oblique insertion directed proximally 0.1 to 0.2 cun, or prick to bleed.

ACTIONS

Revives consciousness

Clears heat and benefits the tongue, eyes and throat

Regulates Heart qi and calms the spirit

INDICATIONS

- Heart pain, pain of the chest and lateral costal region, palpitations, pounding of the Heart, loss of consciousness from windstroke, loss of consciousness, mania-depression, epilepsy, fright epilepsy, excessive sighing, fright and sadness with diminished qi, febrile disease with agitation and restlessness.
- Pain at the root of the tongue, swollen tongue, tongue thrusting, throat painful obstruction, dry throat, heat in the mouth, pain of the eyes, red eyes, yellow eyes, jaundice, malaria, heat in the body like fire.
- Contraction of the hand, pain of the arm, inability to extend the elbow, pain of the palm that radiates to the elbow, axilla and chest.

COMMENTARY

Shaochong HE-9 is the jing-well point, and thus the terminal and most dynamic point, of the Heart shaoyin (lesser yin) channel, hence the name Lesser Rushing. It shares with the jing-well points of the twelve channels three principal characteristics. Firstly it is able to restore consciousness in cases of collapse, for example from windstroke. Secondly, it has a strong action on clearing heat from the opposite end of the channel. The Heart primary channel ascends alongside the oesophagus and connects with the tissues surrounding the eye, the Heart divergent channel ascends along the throat, and the Heart Luo-connecting channel ascends to the root of the tongue and the eye. Shaochong HE-9 is effective to clear heat from the upper reaches of all of these branches of the Heart channel in the tongue (swelling and pain), throat (painful obstruction and dryness), mouth (heat) and eyes (redness and pain), as well as being able to clear febrile heat disturbing the spirit and giving rise to agitation and restlessness. Thirdly the *Classic of Difficulties* states that the jing-well points treat "fullness below the Heart"¹⁰. The region 'below the Heart' specifically refers to the apex of the epigastrium, but many of the jing-well points in fact treat stagnation and fullness throughout the chest region, and Shaochong HE-9 is indicated for pain of the Heart chest and lateral costal region.

Whilst its modern clinical use emphasises the treatment of such excess disorders, classical texts place equal weight on its ability to treat Heart qi deficiency. Thus the *Song of the Jade Dragon* states "What of diseases of cold Gall Bladder and Heart deficiency? Bilateral Shaochong HE-9 is the most effective", and the *Song of the Primary Points*

of the Fourteen Channels similarly prescribes it for Heart and Gall Bladder qi deficiency. Since Shaochong HE-9 is the wood point of the Heart fire channel, this reflects the principle of treating the mother to nourish the child.

COMBINATIONS

- Heat in the mouth: Shaochong HE-9 and Dazhong KID-4 (*Supplementing Life*).
- Fever: Shaochong HE-9 and Quchi L.I.-11 (*One Hundred Symptoms*).
- Fear and fright with Heart pain: Shaochong HE-9, Shenmen HE-7, Yanglingquan GB-34 and Neiguan P-6 (*Compilation*).

NOTES

- 1 *Essential Questions* Chapter 10.
- 2 *Essential Questions* Chapter 44.
- 3 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 8.
- 4 *Essential Questions* Chapter 62.
- 5 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 44.
- 6 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 6.
- 7 Ma Dan-yang was the originator of the *Song of the Eleven Heavenly Star Points*. They first appeared in print in the 12th century CE *Classic of the Jade Dragon*. Xu Feng included this text in his work *Complete Collection of Acupuncture and Moxibustion* and added a twelfth point, Taichong LIV-3.
- 8 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 71.
- 9 Fei Bo Xiong (1800-1879) in Fei Bo Xiong et. al. 1985 *Medical Collection From Four Families from Meng He* (Meng He Si Jia Yi Ji), Jiangsu Science Publishing House, p.40. Quoted in Maciocia, G. *The Practice of Chinese Medicine*, Churchill Livingstone, p. 211.
- 10 Master Hua's *Classic of the Central Viscera* attributed to Hua Tuo, a translation of the *Zong Zang Jing* by Yang Shou-zhong, Blue Poppy Press, 1993.
- 11 *Essential Questions* Chapter 33.
- 12 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 71.
- 13 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 71.
- 14 *Spiritual Pivot* Chapter 8.
- 15 *Classic of Difficulties* 68th Difficulty.
- 16 *Classic of Difficulties* 68th Difficulty.